

Yiwen Zhang

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Inequality; Comparative Political Economy; Computational Social Science; AI Governance

EDUCATION

London School of Economics and Political Science

September 2025 - September 2029

Department of Government (Affiliated with the Data Science Institute)

PhD in Political Science

Passed unconditionally, September 2026; GV599 Research Prospectus in Political Science: 75 (Distinction)

Supervisor: Professor Valentino Larcinese, Dr Pavithra Suryanarayan

Fully funded by the Enlighten Scholarship

Peking University

M.Phil. in Comparative Politics, GPA: 3.87/4.0 (Ranked 1st; Thesis with Distinction)

September 2022 - June 2024

Exchange: **Stanford University** (China Study in Beijing Program; Prof. Scott Rozelle, Prof. Michael McFaul), **University of**

Oxford (International Politics Seminar, Prof. Paul Chaisty), **Sciences Po** (Global Governance Program)

Peking University

B.A. in Politics and Administration, GPA: 3.7/4.0 (Ranked 2nd; Highest Honours)

September 2018 - June 2022

Joint Honours Program in Politics, Law, and Sociology

SELECTED RESEARCH

The Politics of Unequal Protection: Three Essays on Welfare States, Economic Insecurity, and Technological Change

Doctoral research project

- Develops expected residual loss to explain how institutional protection shapes the translation of economic insecurity into political demand.
- Combines an England information experiment, BHPS panel analysis of workplace-pension access/take-up, and 2024 OECD Risks That Matter analysis of AI employment risk and expected state protection.

Aggregate Agreement Is Not Validity: Three Levels of Evidence for LLM-Simulated Public Opinion in China and Britain
Working paper; presented at APSA 2026

- Develops claim-dependent validation for synthetic survey respondents and identifies cross-public structural substitution in redistribution attitudes.

Multi-dimensional Bias in Modeling Multi-dimensional Preferences: Evaluating the Ability of Synthetic Agents to Replace Human Participants in Conjoint Experiments with Ho Ting Hung, Nachiket Midha, and Victor Y. Wu, 2026 *arXiv*

- Evaluates whether LLM-generated synthetic agents can substitute for human respondents in conjoint experiments by replicating seven published political science conjoint studies and benchmarking synthetic responses against original human data.
- Develops a multi-model validation framework comparing synthetic and human preferences across AMCEs, marginal means, distributional similarity, and stability diagnostics.

SELECTED PUBLICATIONS AND RESEARCH OUTPUTS

Burland, Patrick, and Yiwen Zhang. 2025. **Seeing beyond the negative: An examination of key variables in the different reasons for the decisions not to formally recognise people as survivors of modern slavery**. Modern Slavery and Human Rights Policy and Evidence Centre, University of Oxford. Policy report. <https://www.modernslaverypec.org/resources/iom-uk-briefing>.

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

American Political Science Association Annual Meeting, 2022, 2025, 2026

International Conference on Political Sociology, 2024

Chinese Community of Political Science and International Studies Annual Conference, 2023

Midwest Political Science Association Conference, 2022, 2025

SELECTED RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Early Childhood Development Tracking Survey Project

June 2024 - September 2024

Research Assistant | Advisor: Professor Scott Rozelle (Stanford University)

- Assisted in designing rigorous randomized intervention experiments to identify the impact of parenting practices on cognitive development among children in Zhejiang, China, and utilized socioeconomic scales to assess parenting environments and behaviors, providing policy recommendations for improving social welfare policies

- Led the baseline field survey team, conducting on-site interviews and measurements with children and parents, successfully collecting 500 data samples in the first phase. The following steps involve randomly offering scientifically informed family caregiving resources and evaluating the impact of the social intervention

Annual “Beijing Area Study” under the Research Centre for Contemporary China

January 2021 - July 2024

Research Assistant

- Led the research design and conducted comprehensive literature reviews for two modules on Chinese international attitudes and grassroots democratic preferences within the Beijing Area Study. Demonstrated expertise in online experiment design, focusing on creating experiments for choice-based conjoint analysis
- Contributed to developing a research article based on original survey data, leading data cleaning, statistical analysis in R and Python, and drafting key manuscript sections. This experience fostered advanced academic writing skills, a comprehensive understanding of quantitative methods from design to presentation, and the practical application of classic political psychology and communication theories in empirical research

COVID-19 Government Response Tracker (OxCGRT), University of Oxford

January 2021 - March 2023

Data Processing Associate| Advisor: Dr Yuxi Zhang, Professor Thomas Hale (University of Oxford)

- Spearheaded policy coding efforts for numerous provincial-level governments, notably including Shanxi and Guangdong provinces, instrumental in shaping the creation of a pioneering pandemic policy database recognized on a global scale
- Developed my undergraduate thesis using a global multilevel dataset by recoding the OxCGRT dataset into a longitudinal format and integrating multiple waves of individual surveys. Employed a two-way fixed effects model in STATA to demonstrate that stricter containment policies and more economically supportive government actions significantly lead to a leftward shift in public ideology and increased support for government surveillance during crises

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

London School of Economics and Political Science, Department of Government

September 2026 - June 2027

Graduate Teaching Assistant, GV101 Introduction to Political Science

Peking University, School of Government

September 2023 - June 2024

Teaching Assistant, Introduction to Comparative Politics

SELECTED HONOURS & AWARDS

Enlighten Scholarship, £ 200,000, London School of Economics and Political Science	<i>July 2025</i>
The China Scholarship Council Scholarship \$ 26,400	<i>July 2024</i>
Compass Research Scholarship \$ 31,000, University of Chicago	<i>March 2024</i>
Graduate Scholarship for Academic Excellence, ¥44,000, Peking University	<i>September 2022-July 2024</i>
Global Governance Program Scholarship €3,000, Sciences Po & Peking University	<i>October 2023</i>
Forbes China 30 Under 30	<i>December 2023</i>
Leo KoGuan Scholarship \$2,850, Peking University (Top 0.05%)	<i>September 2023</i>
International Alliance of Research Universities Summer School Scholarship £289, University of Oxford	<i>June 2023</i>
Student of the Year Nominee, Peking University (Top 0.1%)	<i>December 2022</i>
May Fourth Scholarship ¥12,000, Peking University (Highest Honours scholarship for undergraduate)	<i>September 2021</i>
Academic Innovation Award, Peking University (The only undergraduate in the department)	<i>September 2021</i>
Peking University “Challenge Cup” Academic Competition First Prize	<i>April 2021</i>

RELATED PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

International Organisation for Migration (UN Migration) in the UK, On-site Full-time Data Intern	<i>August 2024 - July 2025</i>
World Economic Forum Global Shapers Community, Curator of Beijing Hub (Part-time)	<i>January 2024 - Present</i>
“Future Youth” Educational Equality Public Welfare Project, Co-Founder (Part-time)	<i>May 2022 - Present</i>
Development and Reform Commission of Beijing, Intern	<i>March 2021 - May 2021</i>
Institution of New Economy Development, Consultant	<i>July 2020 - September 2020</i>

METHODS AND SKILLS

Research Method: Survey Experiment, Causal Inference, Multilevel Modelling, Panel Data Analysis

Programming and Software: Python, R, Stata, LaTeX, SPSS, Git

Languages: English and Chinese - Advanced proficiency for research and teaching, French - Basic, Spanish - Basic